

Stone jar mystery may be solved

By Chris Simms // 30 May 2026

In central Laos, the landscape is littered with enormous stone jars. The discovery of human remains within them indicates a major role in mortuary practices.

THE remains of at least 37 people have been found interred in a giant stone jar in Laos, reshaping our understanding of one of South-East Asia's most puzzling ancient landscapes.

Around the remote Xieng Khouang plateau in central Laos sit thousands of giant stone jars, some 3 metres high and weighing several tonnes. The Plain of Jars has long been thought to be an ancient megalithic site, but who made the jars and what they were used for have remained mysterious.

"There are all these old stories associated with them, that they were made for giants who used them for brewing rice wine," says Nick Skopal at James Cook University in Australia.

Investigations in the 1930s led to suggestions that the jars were associated with the South-East Asian Iron Age between about 500 BC and AD 500 and were used to cremate or decompose bodies. More recent studies have found glass beads, jewellery and a few cremated remains, as well as burials near the jars but not within them.

Now, Skopal and his colleagues have found the densely packed remains of many people in their excavation of a jar measuring 1.3 metres high and more than 2 metres wide near the town of Phonsavan. The jar contained the right femurs and skulls from 19 individuals, but teeth from 37 people ([Antiquity, doi.org/q646](https://doi.org/q646)).

Radiocarbon dating of samples showed that the remains were deposited in multiple phases over up to 270 years, between the 9th and 12th centuries AD. The remains were neatly packed in, potentially after an initial period of decomposition elsewhere, with the longer bones laid out towards the edges, and many smaller, more fragile bones missing.

"This is an incredibly consequential discovery," says Nigel Chang, also at James Cook University, who wasn't involved in the research. "After almost 100 years of speculation, this is the first of these stone jars to be investigated with irrefutable association with mortuary behaviour."

"Were the stone jars some way for the soul to be released and be prepared for the afterlife as part of ancestor worship?"

About 500 metres from the big, primary jar was a group of smaller stone jars, some of which contained glass beads. Skopal suggests that people put dead bodies inside the smaller jars until the flesh deteriorated, then moved the bones to the larger jar.

"Were the stone jars some way for the soul to be released and be prepared for the afterlife as part of ancestor worship?" he says. "We are doing some DNA testing on these remains inside the jar. That will give us an idea of who these people were and how they were related to each other."

The dating of the samples reveals when this stone jar was being used, but doesn't show when it was made.

"It seems to be becoming clear that there was a lot of activity around the jar sites in the second half of the first millennium AD or so," says Chang. "However, my personal opinion is that the jars themselves are older than that: from 2000 or more years ago."

Unfortunately, you can't date the jars themselves, says Skopal, but he adds that his team's dating of artefacts excavated outside the jar matches what's inside it, which suggests the jar was placed there when the first bodies were put inside. "It's starting to suggest that it's more of a medieval culture, and not an Iron Age thing," he says.

Skopal thinks the practice was part of ancestral funerary rites that spanned generations. But there is great variance in the stone jars in Laos, he adds, so there were probably different ways of using them within the wider tradition. At some sites, jars are generally upright, and many are empty - perhaps because of looting - while at other sites, there are many jars with shallower or narrower internal cavities that are lying flat. That implies differences in rites between regions or over time, he says.

| Tradition and trade

"It is very likely that numerous cultural groups could have utilised the jars, or the same cultural group used the same jar as a mortuary facility over an extended period of time," says Tiatoshi Jamir at Nagaland University in India.

The team also found iron tools, earthenware, a copper-based bell and glass beads inside the larger jar. Chemical analysis revealed the beads were produced in South India and Mesopotamia, indicating long-distance travel and trade.

This isn't unexpected, he says, given that around AD 1000 was a flourishing period in east and South-East Asia, which included the Song Dynasty and Dali Kingdom in China, Cambodia's Khmer Empire and the Pagan kingdom in what is now Myanmar.

Marco Mitri at North Eastern Hill University in India, who has worked on similar stone jars in north-east India, more than 1000 kilometres away, says archaeology is revealing an extensive cultural tradition. He suggests a widespread Austroasiatic population engaged in these funerary

traditions for hundreds of years, with similar rites still used today in India by an Austroasiatic group called the Khasi, who, after cremation, deposit bones in stone boxes called cists.

Comprehensive Key Vocabulary & Academic Expressions

The following expanded glossary provides an exhaustive index of advanced academic, archaeological, and anthropological terminology utilized in the text.

Word / Phrase	Analytical Definition	Contextual Exemplar
Interred	Placed or buried carefully in a grave, tomb, or ritual depository, typically as part of funeral rites.	The remains of at least 37 people have been found interred in a giant stone jar.
Megalithic	Relating to or denoting prehistoric structures or monuments constructed from large, monumental stones.	The Plain of Jars has long been thought to be an ancient megalithic site.
Mortuary	Relating to the burial of the dead, funerary architecture, or specific community funeral customs.	The giant jars played a major role in regional mortuary practices.
Excavation	The systematic unearthing and scientific logging of archaeological artifacts and structural remains.	Skopal and his colleagues found packed remains during their excavation of a primary jar.
Deteriorated	Decayed, eroded, or broken down progressively over time due to organic or atmospheric processes.	Bodies were left inside smaller jars until the flesh deteriorated.
Consequential	Having significant, profound, or far-reaching cultural, historical, or scientific importance.	This is an incredibly consequential discovery for South-East Asian archaeology.
Irrefutable	Impossible to deny, contradict, or disprove; supported by absolute empirical evidence.	This is the first jar to show an irrefutable association with ancient funerary behavior.
Speculation	The formation of an explanatory theory or conjecture without complete, definitive physical proof.	After almost 100 years of speculation, scientific testing has finally begun.

Word / Phrase	Analytical Definition	Contextual Exemplar
Variance	The state, measure, or fact of differing, changing, or exhibiting diversity in layout or style.	There is great variance in the design and orientation of the stone jars in Laos.
Flourishing	Developing rapidly and successfully; experiencing a golden age of economic and cultural output.	Around AD 1000 was a flourishing period marked by massive structural empires.
Plateau	An extensive, elevated area of relatively level high ground.	Thousands of giant stone jars sit around the remote Xieng Khouang plateau.
Cremate	To dispose of a dead body by burning it to ashes, often as a formalized cultural custom.	Early investigations suggested the jars were used to cremate or decompose bodies.
Decompose	To undergo chemical breakdown or organic decay after death.	Smaller jars served as temporary spaces for bodies to decompose prior to final burial.
Radiocarbon Dating	A scientific method used to determine the age of organic material by measuring its carbon-14 content.	Radiocarbon dating of samples showed that the remains were deposited in multiple phases.
Ancestral	Inherited from, belonging to, or relating to a community's forebears or long-standing lineages.	Skopal thinks the practice was part of ancestral funerary rites that spanned generations.
Funerary	Relating to a funeral or the commemoration of the dead.	Widespread Austroasiatic populations engaged in these unique funerary traditions.
Cavities	Hollow spaces, internal openings, or deep chambers within a solid physical object.	Some sites contain jars with much shallower or narrower internal cavities.
Looting	The illicit plundering, stealing, or unauthorized removal of	Many of the upright stone jars are currently empty, perhaps because of historical looting.

Word / Phrase	Analytical Definition	Contextual Exemplar
	historical artifacts from an archaeological site.	
Earthenware	Pottery made of clay fired to a porous state, typically representing localized technological skill.	The team also recovered iron tools, earthenware, and a copper bell inside the repository.
Austroasiatic	A large language family of Southeast Asia and Northeast India, used anthropologically to trace historic populations.	Similar rites are still used today in India by an Austroasiatic group called the Khasi.